

Interactive Graphics Systems

2025-2026

Practical classes

Project: Underwater ecosystem

1. Introduction

The aim of this work is to study and apply the knowledge presented in the theoretical classes of SGI. You will be accomplishing this goal with an application developed over the next nine weeks.

This edition's theme is an aquarium / marine underwater ecosystem which includes multiple elements such as fish, minerals, plants, corals, terrain, particles, different camera configurations, as well as lighting effects. This theme provides a rich experimental environment where your team can apply all the contents taught in SGI as well as those acquired from self-study.

The primary goals are:

- Develop an interactive 3D underwater environment in three.js (other extensions can be used provided they are justified and agreed with the teacher).
- Apply computer graphics fundamentals (geometry, transformations, lighting, textures, animation, collisions).
- Incorporate GLSL shaders for underwater visual enhancements.
- Create an immersive environment where users can explore the aquarium, interact with fish, and experience realistic ocean effects.

The project description will be released in three parts, to help segment the topics. This document will be updated as each new part is released.

2. Plan

Week 1 (6 October): Cameras, Primitives, and Transformations

- Set up the project framework: in the “pw2” folder of your git repository, create an empty scene (suggestion: copy pw1 files and adapt them as necessary)
- Implement multiple camera perspectives (“free-fly”, underwater view, fixed aquarium view), supported by a 2D GUI
- Create classes that are subclasses of Object3D to represent each of the following elements: terrain segments, rocks, corals, fish, bubbles. Create basic geometric primitives as placeholders for each of those classes (spheres for bubbles, cubes/planes for rocks/terrain segments, cylinders for corals, small blocks for fish).
- Structure these elements internally as a scene graph, e.g. creating a node that groups multiple fish, another that groups corals, etc.
- Apply transformations to position corals, plants, and rocks into a basic seafloor scene.
- For the mentioned features, when viewing the scene, it should be possible to switch between the “fill” and “wireframe” polygonal mode through a control also located in the GUI.
- **Milestone:** Initial static 3D environment with camera controls.
- **Git tag:** basic-modelling
- **Keep in mind:** At this point, it is more important to have the basic internal structure and scene structure, than to try to create a lot of objects and invest in their looks (that will be for later). It should be a strong scaffold for the following parts.

Week 2 (13 October): BufferGeometry, LOD, L-Systems, scene Improvements

- Replace fish geometry by a BufferGeometry that defines a set of vertices and their connectivity to form triangles, and parameterize its constructor so that the proportions of the fish body, fins and color/texture can vary (see image below for geometry suggestion).
Add a top/dorsal fin and two belly fins as sub-objects of the fish, to allow for animation later.
(Check TriangleBufferGeometry and BufferGeometry demos in Moodle).

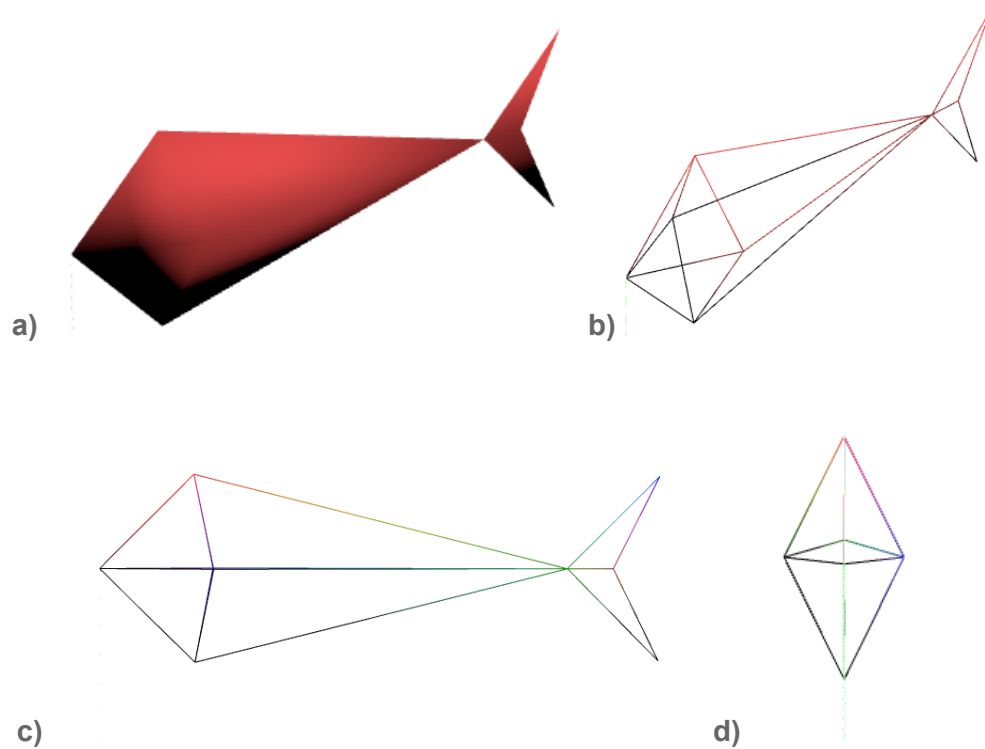


Figure 1: Suggestion for a basic fish geometry

a) Perspective shaded; b) Perspective wireframe
c) Side view; d) Front view

- Use Stochastic L-Systems (L-Systems with probabilities) to generate different corals.
(check *Stochastic L-Systems in ObjectRepresentation demo in Moodle*).
- Implement a simple Level of Detail (LOD) approach for distant fish and coral to optimize rendering i.e. if they are farther than a threshold distance, use the basic blocks with the material instead of the detailed geometry.
(Check *LOD demo in Moodle*)
- Improve the scenegraph hierarchy if necessary (parent/child relationships for fish groups, coral clusters, etc.).
- **Milestone:** Efficient, hierarchical scene structure with varied models.
- **Git tag:** improved-modelling

Week 3 (October 20th): Animation

- Create an animated version of the fish using a simple skeleton of two or three bones (the fish “spine” divided into two to three segments) and defining the weight for each vertex of your fish geometry, i.e. each vertex should have a set of two or three weights associated. If useful, add additional vertices/triangles to your fish mesh (*Check Skinning 2D and 3D demos in Moodle*)
- Animate the bones so that the front joint and the back joint move in a periodic left-right movement, bending the fish's body in the extremities. (*Check Interpolation Animation demo in Moodle*)
- Implement a simple keyframe animation mechanism, that given a sequence of positions underwater (a path, that can be generated randomly) and timing information, animates the position and orientation of an object. Apply that to some fish (each will have its path, some may have similar paths to move close to each other). (*Check Keyframe Animation demo in Moodle*)
- Animate seaweed and corals using sine-wave deformation to simulate underwater swaying. (*Check Interpolation Animation demo in Moodle*)
- **Milestone:** Animated underwater scene.
- **Git tag:** animation

Weeks 4, 5 (October 27th, November 3rd): Interaction

- Create a submarine that is to be controlled by the user with the keyboard
 - Simple geometry: horizontal capsule with a short vertical cylinder for the hatch (and an optional “L-shaped” tube for a periscope)
 - Keys ‘W’ and ‘S’ increase/decrease horizontal forward speed
 - Keys ‘A’ and ‘D’ change horizontal direction left or right
 - Keys ‘P’ and ‘L’ increase/decrease vertical upward speed
 - Make the “submarine” camera follow the submarine, as a first-person camera.
- Create a group of fish that uses the flock/boids approach to simulate a school of fish (“cardume”), that band together while moving around, using the Reynolds rules (<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Boids>, check also *Flocking Demo* in Moodle)
 - rule 1: separation
 - rule 2: alignment
 - rule 3: cohesion
- Add a rule of avoidance that makes each fish move away abruptly from dangerous entities, and make the submarine one of those dangerous entities (other entities might be one or two larger keyframe-animated fish, such as sharks)
- Add simple UI elements to control flocking parameters, and camera views.
- **Milestone:** Interactive exploration of the ecosystem.
- **Git tag:** interaction

Week 6 (November 10th): Indexing techniques, intersection and collision detection

(Note: The acceleration features presented next must coexist with the so far, non-accelerated version of code)

- Integrate a Bounding Volume Hierarchy (BVH) structure that works with three.js geometry (such as <https://github.com/gkjohnson/three-mesh-bvh>) to efficiently index scene objects.
- Implement a 2D GUI control that allows the user to enable/disable acceleration, switching between the BVH-based and the exhaustive/brute-force implementation for the proximity checks below.
- The BVH should consider bounding boxes for the submarine, any larger keyframe-animated fish (like sharks), and the individual boids (flocking fish). You must ensure that BufferGeometries are correctly indexed by BVH
- Use the BVH structure to accelerate flocking computations by quickly identifying the relevant neighbors of a fish (both other fish, sharks, corals and submarine) - *proximity query*. This will allow each fish to calculate the necessary accelerations without iterating through *all* fish/entities in the scene.
- Integrate the BVH into an object selection process (picking), in which the user can use the mouse to select one of the entities - *intersection query*. The selected entity should be highlighted by changing its material in some way (if another entity was selected, it should be deselected).
- **Milestone:** Efficient spatial queries supporting flocking and avoidance.
- **Git tag:** acceleration

(The next part will be published soon; see general evaluation details in the next page)

3. Evaluation

Final Deliverables

- An interactive 3D Aquarium implemented in three.js. Make sure your application works on any computer and there are no hardwired files that work on the development environment and fail on other computers. The downloaded version of your work should be able to showcase a live demonstration containing camera views, animated ecosystem, interaction and collisions, lighting, textures, particles and performance optimizations (for instance, despite complexity, framerate is still high)
- A README.md file with:
 - Course ID
 - Class ID
 - Workgroup ID
 - Student names
 - Brief description of design choices, optimizations, shader implementations, known limitations and features not developed.
 - Describe the distribution of work among the students in the workgroup and, for each student summarize its responsibilities.

Composition of Groups: The work is carried out in groups of three students, ideally.

Group Work Assessment: The code resulting from group work will be presented and defended in the classroom, to the respective teacher. The three students in the group must be present at the assessment session (if this is impossible, they must previously agree on an alternative with the practical classes' teacher). The classification given to the three students may be different.

Students must split responsibilities evenly (for instance, modeling/geometry, animation/interaction, optimization/shaders). Transversally to the evaluation criteria presented in this document, a peer evaluation will be considered as part of the project evaluation. Lack of task ownership could cause overlaps or uneven contributions.

Use of AI tools: Although these are not prohibited, you should limit their use to help you understand things, not doing things for you. When using them, you should be critical about whatever the results from AI you depend on, and you should always be able to understand and discuss the code you submit. You don't learn by copy-pasting large swaths of code, and you lose your critical thinking abilities fast if you do so.

Assessment will focus on (details in the table below):

- The fulfilment of the functionalities defined, not forgetting:
- Controllability of the scene via the 2D interface
- The creativity put into the scene
- Developed code quality and comments
- Individual understanding of the code

Assessment will be based on weekly observations/discussions in class, code evolution, final results and presentation.

Suggested week	Content	Value
1	Cameras, Primitives, Transformations (scene setup, basic models)	1.5
2	Scene and object representation improvements	2.0
3	Animation	2.0
4	Interaction	2.0
5	Occlusion and Collision	1.5
6	Lighting & Shadows	2.0
7	Advanced Textures	1.5
8	Acceleration Techniques	1.5
9	Particle Systems	1.5
	Code quality and organization (naming conventions, modular structure, commenting)	1.5
	Creativity	3.0
	Total	20

Main dates

- Start: 6 October 2025
- Final delivery: 19th Dec 2025